

CELESTIALS • BOOK ONE

COVENANT



MEREDITH TAYLOR

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Covenant

Book One of the
Celestials
Series

Meredith Taylor

COVENANT: CELESTIALS BOOK 1

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*“And with the rise of the Sibyl
Three harbingers will call to the Celestials
Announcing the coming of the Behemoth
And the rupture of the Veil.”*

From *The Book of the Za-kale*, translated from ancient
Chthon

Chapter 1

The girl sat humming a made-up tune on the back seat as her mother drove the car on the misty highway. Her small legs barely crept over the front of the seat. She watched the light from the street lamps dance over the plastic toy that she turned in her hands, an eagle in mid-flight. Of the few toys she owned, the eagle was her favorite. She often imagined herself able to lift off from the earth and take flight, just like the bird, going wherever she wanted. Not feeling restricted or hidden away like she had been for so long. A taste of real freedom.

“Mom, why can’t we take a plane to grandma instead of driving all the way?” the girl asked in her gentle voice. She pushed her long, curly brown hair from her face as she continued to make her toy soar in the changing patterns of light. The night was cold, and her legs were covered with the blanket that her grandmother had crocheted for her on her first birthday, a checkered green and yellow blanket that she took along whenever her mother made her pack up in the middle of the night. She had gotten used to always moving, noticing the signs of her mother’s growing restlessness. Her mother would become quiet for a few days, more distant, and the girl knew to prepare herself for another long car ride and a new apartment to get used to.

“You know I hate flying, Onyx,” her mother called back. “There’s way too much up there we don’t understand.” Her mother was smiling in the rear-view mirror, pointing towards the sky, but Onyx did not return her smile.

“I like flying,” Onyx said under her breath. A few months before, her mother had come to get her after a

vacation with her grandmother. Her mother had to leave in the middle of the night with her friend Teddy, the woman who showed up almost every time Onyx's life was uprooted. Onyx had taken her first plane trip on that vacation with her grandmother, and thought about it often. The feeling of weightlessness when they finally left the ground, her stomach jumping at the change in altitude. The rush of going so fast she wasn't sure the plane would ever be able to stop without crashing. As she pulled her checkered blanket closer to her waist, she remembered how her mother held her tightly when Onyx came home from that trip, how she promised to never leave her side again.

"Tell you what," her mother called back, giving an even broader smile in the mirror, "we can go on a Ferris wheel at the amusement park near Gia's house. That's almost like flying, isn't it?"

Onyx forced a weak smile, meeting her mother's eyes in the rear-view mirror. It wasn't the same, she thought. Not like really being up there in the clouds.

Onyx hummed her song again and closely followed the lights that danced on her eagle. But the light had grown strange, changed somehow. It was no longer the soft yellow of street lamps reflecting from the plastic toy. Instead, she saw the light grow brighter, a blue-white glow that slowly enveloped the eagle and then the entire back seat. Onyx turned to look out of the car window. There was a brief flash of a brilliant blue light next to her that she squinted into, warm on her face. She raised her arm to shield her eyes, and when she looked again she saw something else; a face in the night, right next to her window. The face was only there for a split second, and when it disappeared Onyx felt a powerful force. Her head jerked forward as her mother hit the brakes and swerved to avoid something in the road. The screech of tires made her heart race. She dropped her toy to the ground in front of her seat, and gripped tightly to her blanket.

“Put your head down!” her mother shouted. “Onyx, stay down!”

The blue-white light became even brighter, and Onyx closed her eyes tightly, bending her head forward as the car swerved sharply to the left. “Mom, what’s happening?” she called out, her voice panicky and high-pitched. The blanket fell from her knees as the car swerved again, and she felt every muscle in her tiny body become tense.

“Don’t let them see you, Onyx!” her mother shouted. For a moment, Onyx caught another glimpse of her mother’s eyes in the rear-view mirror. They were large, fearful, the pupils dilated in the green irises. Her mother bent over to the passenger seat to take something out of the glove compartment, keeping one hand on the wheel. Onyx ducked her head down as far as it could go, feeling her seatbelt tug at her chest and her heart beating so fast that she felt its pounding rock her body.

And then she heard the crash, and felt the world stop around her.

In the quiet after the car hit the concrete road barrier, Onyx heard muffled voices. It sounded like two people arguing very close to where she lay motionless on the back seat, her body only held up by her seatbelt. And then, with her vision still blurry, she lifted her head and saw the brilliant blue-white light fade to black. In the stillness, she whispered: “Mom?”

“Wake up, Onyx! You can’t sleep all the way through the road trip!” Hayley said as she shook Onyx’s knee. Onyx sat upright in the passenger seat, feeling the familiar pain in her arm that had been there ever since the car crash. Only a dream. Still as vivid as ever, and she felt a rush of embarrassment as she wondered if she had really spoken that final “Mom” in the

twilight between sleep and waking, and if Hayley had heard her.

“Sorry,” Onyx said to her friend, “it’s just been a long week. But I’ll be the life of the party tonight. Don’t worry about it.” She turned to where Hayley sat in the driver’s seat of her car and gave a weak smile. They were cruising down the highway at a steady pace, getting further away from the city. Onyx looked at herself in the mirror of her sun visor, wiping her eyes. Her hair was tied back in a ponytail, the brown curls pushed behind her ears. It had been twenty-three years since her mother had died, and Onyx’s reflection began to remind her more and more of her mother’s face. The same green eyes that she had seen in that rear view mirror on that misty night. The same full lips and olive skin. Even the same expression of apprehension and uncertainty that her mother had always seemed to carry, like something threatening was always at her heels, waiting to pounce. Onyx lifted the sun visor to hide the mirror, and felt the sun on her face.

“You’d better be,” Hayley said. “It’s your birthday weekend. You need to let loose.”

Onyx continued to make idle chatter with Hayley throughout the rest of the trip, but her mind was elsewhere. Her dreams had intensified over the previous few weeks, sometimes of her mother, and other times violent dreams of dark figures that she couldn’t quite make out, but that she knew wanted to hurt her. She couldn’t shake the feeling that something bad was about to happen. Hayley would simply make fun of her whenever Onyx shared any apprehension in the weeks leading up to the trip, saying that Onyx always imagined the worst and that she never just let herself be happy. Hayley had been a great friend to Onyx over the years; they had met in high school and both ended up working as journalists at the same news website, *The L.A. Monocle*, after college. Hayley could always find the light when Onyx drifted into darkness. Her long, blonde hair and perfect make-up

made Onyx feel a bit like an ugly duckling in her company, and Hayley's infectious personality always ensured that they were surrounded by crowds—and handsome men—wherever they went.

Onyx resolved to be upbeat, despite the unnerving dreams. It was her 28th birthday, after all, and it had been a long time since her mother had died. Onyx still felt like she was stuck in that moment; she had never found clarity about what had caused her mother to swerve off the road that night, what the bright light was that she saw, or who the people were who whispered after the car crash. She wondered, too, whether she had simply imagined the face she had seen in the car window; after all this time, she hardly remembered what it looked like. But she resolved to push away all of those thoughts and be good company to Hayley. She would leave the past in the past.

After another thirty minutes of driving, they pulled onto a dirt road, rows of trees lining it and the smells of the forest hitting Onyx's nose. The road was bumpy, and Hayley's small car barely absorbed the impact of the rocky ride. Onyx felt a bit of motion sickness, and reached into her bag to find a pill that usually helped to calm her stomach. She had grown to hate traveling and to dread the feeling of being out of control of her own body.

Finally, after another twenty minutes on the dirt road, they saw the cabin where they would be staying for the weekend, a small wooden two-bedroom with a hot tub on the deck. Hayley smiled at Onyx as she parked the car next to the cabin. She said: "This looks amazing! It's just like Chris described it."

Onyx nodded and forced a smile. "It looks great."

"By the way, Chris brought his friend Byron along. He's super cute." Hayley gave a mischievous wink.

Onyx rolled her eyes and groaned. “Another set-up? You know how this usually goes. Everyone you introduce me to is really just into you.”

“That’s not true,” Hayley responded sternly, a bit too loudly to be believable. “You have a lot to offer, Onyx. You’re gorgeous, and you’re an excellent journalist. That piece on corruption at the DA’s office... That was some top-notch journalism. You’ve been through a lot and I just want you to be happy.”

“Thanks, Hayley,” Onyx replied. She pushed aside the memories of her bad dreams, the sense of dread that she was feeling, and decided that she owed it to Hayley to make the most of her birthday weekend.

The day had been a blur of long stories from Hayley, her favorite indie rock band crooning from the speakers they had set up in the kitchen, and Hayley’s boyfriend, Chris, showing them photos of his latest hunting trip. Byron, Chris’s friend, was quiet, and Onyx had tried a few times throughout the day to learn more about him, but his one-word answers to her questions had begun to wear on her. He was handsome enough, with a square jaw and a buzz cut that hid his slight balding, but his personality irked Onyx. She hated making small talk in general, but she was trying for Hayley’s sake. As the sun began to set, Onyx played with the rim of her beer can as they sat outside the cabin near the fire pit, Chris gesturing wildly as he described a particularly resilient stag that he had taken down with an expert shot. Onyx winced at the story; she hated hunting but tried to maintain a few half-hearted words of approval at the stories Chris shared. She had once joined Hayley and Chris on a hunting trip and watched him shoot a deer, walking over to the lifeless body with them in the aftermath. For some reason, all she could see when she

looked into the deer's eyes was her mother, and she felt like she wanted to throw up.

Eventually, after Chris took a short break in his story, Onyx stood up. She turned to Hayley and said: "I need some air. Just going to walk a bit."

"It's pitch dark out here! Why don't you come and get another drink with me?" Hayley pouted playfully, something she would often do when she saw Onyx begin to withdraw. It felt at times like Onyx was in a constant push and pull with Hayley trying to get her to open up and enjoy life more. Usually, Onyx was happy to let Hayley win; she knew that Hayley loved her and only wanted what was best for her. But at times, Onyx felt like there was something inside of her scratching at the inside of her skull, like she was barely able to keep some indescribable demon at bay. At those times, Hayley's insistence would be grating. Couldn't she see that Onyx was doing her best?

Onyx pointed up at the full moon, encircled by a ring of light and the stars shining bright in the night sky. "There's plenty of light," she said. "I won't go far. I'm sure there's nothing out there that I can't handle."

Chris interjected in his singsong voice, not looking up at Hayley as he explained: "It's a controlled area. Nothing but some deer and squirrels out there. Maybe a fox or two, but you should be okay. Too many people around for the mountain lions to venture out this far."

"Mountain lions?" Hayley said with a start. But she saw the look in Onyx's eye and withdrew. "Okay, but don't go too far," Hayley said, raising her eyebrow. "I hope you're having fun. You've been in your head a lot these past few weeks. I just want you to let loose a bit."

Onyx nodded and gave a tight-lipped smile. She always felt self-conscious when Hayley spoke like this in front of other people, but Hayley was often unfiltered with her thoughts. "I really appreciate you planning this trip for my

birthday. And I'm having a lot of fun." She hadn't told Hayley about the dreams that had caused her to barely get a few hours of sleep every night for the past two weeks. Nor had she mentioned the thoughts of her mother, or the pain in her upper arm that seemed to be returning with full force after all these years.

She walked along the path behind the cabin, hearing Chris launch into another meandering story as she moved out of sight into a clearing in the woods. There were other cabins not too far away and she could see some lights through the trees. The night was chilly and the white light of the moon made everything feel like it was part of a hazy dream. The wind rustled through the trees and Onyx pulled her jacket tighter around her waist. She thought of the checkered blanket, the one her grandmother had made for her that she couldn't look at after the car crash. No matter how many times she washed it, she still imagined she could see traces of blood in the white of the fabric.

As she looked up at the moon, she heard a powerful gust of wind in the distance and saw the trees sway in unison. Even though she stood in place, the sounds of her friends partying in the distance seemed to be growing fainter. She felt a tightening of the skin on her face. And then, the rushing and whistling of the wind turned into something rhythmic, a repetitive whooshing like the flapping of a giant wing. In the distance, near where the moon hung in the night sky, she saw a sudden flash of brilliant light. Her heart stood still. It was the same blue-white light she had seen on the night of the car crash; she was certain of it. And it was moving through the sky towards where she stood.

Chapter 2

As quickly as the light had moved towards her, it began moving erratically through the sky and seemed to be retreating further into the woods. Onyx barely had a chance to think before she found herself sprinting through the trees; she had to get to the source of the light as soon as she could. This could finally be the chance for her to get answers about what happened that night her mother died.

She pushed through the undergrowth and felt twigs and thorns scratching at her arms and pricking through her jeans, but she disregarded the pain. Nothing was as important as getting to the source of the light. She could still see it in the distance, through the thick woods, making shadows that shifted over the ground in front of her. Her breath was short and shallow, and her heart was pounding frantically. She pushed more undergrowth out of her way, and felt her foot hit a concealed rock before she lost her footing. In an instant she went face-first into the ground, feeling the dirt against her soft cheek. Her hair had come loose from its ponytail in the rush, and as she lifted herself from the ground she pulled off the hair tie to let her curls fall over her face. It was still the same length it had been all those years ago, when she had first seen the blue light. As she continued to run through the woods, she finally found a clearing, but the light was gone.

She looked around in every direction; the trees were so tall that the light of the low-hanging moon was obscured and she could barely see anything. In the distance, she heard Hayley's voice calling her name. She hadn't gotten far, but she

knew that if she continued going aimlessly into the woods, there was a good chance she could get lost. She remembered what her mother had always told her about sticking to paths she knew, not straying, always staying safe. For a split second she thought about going back towards the sound of Hayley's voice. But the sound of something rhythmically rushing through the wind made her turn her head.

She could barely believe her eyes. In front of her, elevated above the ground, was a man, slightly taller than she was, with pale blue eyes staring straight back at her. He was showered in the same blue-white light that she had seen darting through the sky only moments before. But her eyes were drawn to his shoulders, to his back, where there were two wings spread six feet on either side of him, with white feathers reflecting the moonlight. Onyx stared at the figure transfixed. She stumbled backwards, almost falling. She managed to whisper, "What the..."

As Onyx found her footing, she heard the man say in a booming voice: "You can see me?" As her eyes adjusted to the light glowing around the man, she saw that he had medium-length blond hair, swaying in the gusts created by his broad wings. He flapped his wings once more and shot up in the sky, his feet hovering about thirty feet above the ground. From the gentle way he moved his wings, it seemed that they were not the only source of his flight, and the glow surrounding him helped to propel him upwards. He wore dark jeans and a white t-shirt that was torn at the arms and chest and Onyx could see a large wound on his shoulder. His blue eyes bore into her; he seemed to be just as much in disbelief as she was.

Onyx's mouth was dry and she felt lightheaded. Despite the shock, she knew that she had to confront the person in front of her. Memories of her mother flashed in her mind. She shouted back, the rushing of the man's wings now muffling

her voice, “Were you there when my mother died? I’ve seen that light before. What are you?”

The man’s brow furrowed. He shook his head, and as he began to open his mouth, Onyx saw something else creep in the trees behind him. A dark shadow glided across the ground, leaping from the clearing towards the flying man. “Look out!” Onyx called, pointing to the creature, but it was too late. The creature had shot up into the sky and pounced on the flying man, snatching him in its claws and pinning him to the ground. Onyx stepped backward, now convinced that what she was seeing couldn’t be real. The creature attacking the man looked like a giant dog, the size of a pickup truck and with long claws that stretched out in front of it. The creature’s mouth looked like a bear trap with fangs that hung low around its large jaw. Most frightening were the red, glowing eyes that were trained on the man pinned to the ground as its jaw snapped. The man held onto its neck, pushing back to keep the deadly jaws away from his face.

Despite her voice retreating in her throat, she managed to shout out, “Stop!” The creature turned its giant head to fix its red eyes on Onyx, and in a split second the winged man managed to push the giant beast off of him. With another flash of light, a long sword appeared in his hand out of midair, seemingly materializing out of nothing, and he swung it at the beast’s shoulder, cutting deep into its flesh. The beast screeched in pain, and as the winged man took flight again, Onyx watched the creature chase after him.

“Stay here,” the man said flatly to Onyx as he led the beast deeper into the forest, flapping his powerful wings at a greater speed to accelerate into the cover of the dense trees. The beast was close behind him, knocking back trees with its shoulders. Onyx could hardly catch her breath as the light from the winged man grew more distant and silence returned to the clearing. Her eyes were still wide in disbelief, and she breathed heavily.

Behind her, she could hear Hayley's voice calling out again, and she finally saw her friend appear through the woods, shining a torch at Onyx's face. Chris and Byron were there too, all seeming shocked to find Onyx so far away from the cabin.

"Thank God we found you!" Hayley said through her heavy breaths. "What the hell was all of that noise? It sounded like trees were being knocked over! We followed the sound here to find you." Hayley ran over and hugged Onyx, and Onyx could finally feel all of the pain from her scrapes and falls that had been dulled by adrenaline.

"I need to keep going," Onyx said, her eyes darting from side to side. Her mind was racing and her eyes were unfocused. "There's something in the forest... some kind of creature. It's attacking a man."

"What? Keep going? You must've hit your head, Onyx!" Hayley said. She turned to Chris and commanded, "Chris, run back and get your gun. It might be a bear attack. Onyx, you have to come back with me. The cabin isn't too far. Chris and Byron will go after the bear and we can call for help. You're hurt."

Hayley was holding Onyx's arm tightly, clearly struggling to make sense of why Onyx would run off on her own, but Onyx pulled her arm away in one swift motion and before anyone could stop her, she was sprinting through the trees again in the direction where she had last seen the creature disappear. She ran so fast that her legs hurt. She couldn't see the light anymore, but she still heard the faint sounds of struggle and the rustling of leaves ahead of her. All she could think about was that she was finally so close to getting answers about what had happened to her mother. The glow from the winged man was too similar to what she had seen that night; the man must know something. It would explain why she had seen a face following her next to her car window,

driving down a highway. Someone who could fly the way the winged man could must have been following them.

She ran faster than she had in years, not stopping when she almost tumbled over rocks or fallen trees, desperate not to lose the sound of giant wings whooshing through the trees. Finally, she found another clearing, and she stopped herself just in time, the dirt and stones giving way under her feet as she screeched to a halt. She stood at the edge of a cliff, the moonlight reflecting on the lake beyond the cliff's edge. Next to her, the creature and the winged man were locked in a struggle. The man had seemingly managed to do a lot of damage to the creature, with large slashes on its flank and one leg limping, but there were also fresh wounds on the winged man's leg, and his wing looked like it had been damaged in the flight, a patch of feathers missing and blood staining the edge. Onyx watched as the giant, dog-like creature raised its claw to the sky, ready to strike, and the man thrust his sword into the creature's chest. There was a deafening howl, and the creature stumbled backwards, close to where Onyx was standing. She turned to move out of its way, but as she turned her head she saw Hayley and the others move out of the clearing.

"What are you doing, Onyx?" Hayley called out, just as the creature stumbled backwards, its rump knocking into Onyx and pushing her over the edge of the cliff.

Onyx let out a piercing scream, managing to push herself away from the creature that was falling next to her, but still unable to grab onto the cliff's edge before she was tumbling towards the dark water below her. The last thing she saw was Hayley's frightened eyes staring at her before she was looking up at the sky, her feet off solid ground. Images of her mother and grandmother flashed through her mind, and she imagined herself hitting the icy cold water, bracing herself. She knew it would only be a few seconds until she felt the impact. She closed her eyes tightly. She knew instantly that there was no chance she would survive the fall, and she settled on

imagining the face of her mother before she felt her back hit something solid with a heavy thud, mere seconds after falling. But she was not under water like she had imagined, and with her eyes still tightly closed, she felt herself being lifted up through the air. And then she heard the familiar sound of air being pushed by a heavy wing. When she opened her eyes, she saw the face of the winged man looking back at her, his blond hair hanging over his face and his cheeks flushed. "I've got you," he said.

The man lifted her through the air back up to the edge of the cliff. She could feel his warm body pressed against her; she knew that she could not have been imagining any of it. He set her down softly on the ground, and moments after touching the ground she was embraced by Hayley. Hayley cried into Onyx's chest as she hugged her tightly.

"How the hell did you do that? I saw you fall off the edge! How did you get back up here?" Onyx could hear Chris on the phone with emergency services saying that they needed help immediately, that their friend had been injured.

"What are you talking about?" Onyx asked, trying to regain her senses. She looked behind her, but the winged man was gone. "Didn't you see that creature push me off the edge? Didn't you see the man carrying me back up here?" Onyx's mind was racing and she spoke frantically.

Hayley put her hand on her friend's head. "You must've hit your head or something. There was nothing else out here but you. I thought you were... Why were you running out here in the first place? What's going on with you, Onyx?"

Onyx hugged her friend back tightly. She was convinced that it had all been real. Only moments before she was staring into the winged man's eyes, feeling him holding her just as clearly as she felt Hayley's hands around her. But Hayley had not seen any of it.

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“I don’t know,” Onyx replied, and sighed heavily into Hayley’s shoulder. “I saw him.” As Hayley continued to hold her tightly, Onyx whispered: “I know I saw him.”

Chapter 3

Sweat poured from Onyx's face as she held her hands in tight fists in front of her, stalking the punching bag in the middle of the ring. Her muscular shoulders were ready for the next strike. She fixed her eyes on the bag, picturing no one in particular; perhaps a ghost that had haunted her for decades, something she couldn't verbalize. The bright red of the punching bag was the only constant over the years. She took a sharp breath and swung her leg in a roundhouse kick, striking the bag hard, and lashed out in a fury of punches, each followed by a heavy grunt. Her mother had made her start training in various forms of martial arts since she was four, and had made her promise that she would continue training no matter what. "You never know when you'll need it," her mother had said. Taekwondo and Muay Thai had stuck, and Onyx felt a sense of release every time she entered the gym, stood in the boxing ring with the punching bag as her sole focus. It gave her a sense of power when everything else felt out of control. And things seemed to be spinning more out of control than ever before.

Onyx moved quickly, her lithe body floating around the swinging bag. She jabbed forcefully, feeling the energy shift from her core all the way down her arm and out through her clenched fist. She gave a front kick that connected with the bag with a loud thud that echoed through the empty gym. Her breath was controlled despite the exertion. The training was a form of mediation, and she always left with more clarity. Over the past weeks, it had been the only time that she had not

been plagued by thoughts of her incessant, vivid dreams. Or the winged man she had seen the night of her birthday.

She gave another roundhouse kick, feeling her muscles tremor as she landed on the ground. A few curls of her brown hair had come loose from her ponytail and now hung over her face. She pushed her hair behind her ear, feeling the familiar buzz that came when she pushed herself to the edge in her training. She sat down on a nearby bench and towed her face. She was still restless. Even her training couldn't fully distract her from the unbelievable experience she had been through.

In the nights following the strange encounter with the winged man, Onyx's dreams had been intensifying. She dreamed of the man who caught her, his gentle expression as he looked at her in disbelief, his piercing blue eyes and the magnificent wings that stretched from his shoulder blades. At other times, she dreamt of the creature she saw, the red-eyed dog-like monster with the powerful claws, something she could not believe was real. But one dream in particular made her toss and turn in the night, feeling as real as anything she experienced when she was awake. She saw something breaking through a wall, something large and horrifying. The creature looked similar to the one that had attacked the winged man, but it was colossal in scale, almost three hundred feet tall and with giant horns on its head and spiky protrusions on its back and shoulders. The creature had white markings on its legs and a snake-like tail that swerved menacingly behind it. It rammed its massive body against the wall, desperate, determined to get through, baring its teeth as it howled a high-pitched screech. But there were still parts of the creature's body that were obscured, something even more threatening hiding in the shadows. Onyx awoke from those dreams with a start, her brow covered in sweat and her heart racing in her chest. She felt—almost knew—that the creature

was after her somehow and that she would have to stop it breaking through that wall.

She showered and left the gym with thoughts still swimming in her mind. She vividly remembered the night when she had seen the winged man. Hayley had tried to convince her that she had simply imagined it all, that she must've been under too much stress at work or had just seen strange shapes in the woods through a trick of the light. "You definitely had a guardian angel that night, but I think it was metaphorical, not literal," Hayley quipped a few times over the days since the incident. Onyx felt a sting of frustration each time her friend sarcastically referred to the "guardian angel" that saved her; she had gotten the feeling over the years that Hayley didn't really believe her when she described the blue-white lights that she had seen the night her mother died, or the fact that she saw a face hovering next to her car window and heard hushed voices in the aftermath. But Onyx knew what she had seen and felt. Besides, how would it be possible for her to fall from the cliff and then find herself back on the edge unless the winged man had caught her? Hayley had admitted that it was strange, that she couldn't understand seeing Onyx fall over the edge and then simply float back up, but she swore that she did not see any winged man bathed in light.

Onyx couldn't shake the thoughts, and was completely useless at work over the following weeks. She felt like everything was leading her back to her mother and to the strange way she had acted when Onyx was a child. There would be long stretches where her mother, Allegra, disappeared, mostly with the dark-haired woman, Teddy, whom Onyx had not seen again since her mother's death. She realized that the only person she could talk to about her mother was her grandmother, and Onyx decided to visit her. She drove away from the gym determined to find out anything that her grandmother could tell her about her mother's death.

Her grandmother's home was an hour's drive from Los Angeles, near the mountains of San Bernardino. Onyx had wanted to stay close to her grandmother after college, growing attached to Los Angeles after spending so much time moving around with her mother as a child. She wanted to hold on to the last family that she knew. Her grandmother, whom Onyx had always called Gia, stood outside of her modest two-bedroom house as Onyx's car pulled up. The house was on a large plot of land, with a coop of chickens in the front yard and three large happy mutts that ran up to Onyx's car as she arrived. Onyx gave each of the dogs pats and scratches, and waved to Gia, who returned a large, open smile. As Onyx moved closer to hug her, she smelled the familiar smells of her childhood, Gia's lavender perfume and cinnamon wafting from the nearby kitchen window. "You're making cinnamon rolls?" Onyx smiled.

"Of course! I had to make your favorite for your visit. It's been months since you last came around." Gia's heavy brown and gray curls were cut to shoulder length, and she wore a long floral dress and a light denim jacket.

They sat down at the small kitchen table and enjoyed the cinnamon rolls together, and Onyx fidgeted with her fingers as she tried to find a way to ask her grandmother all of the questions that were swimming in her mind. She moved to open her lips but couldn't find the words.

"What's wrong, Onyx? You've looked nervous since you walked through the door. Is there something going on?"

Onyx took a deep breath. Her grandmother had fussed over her since she was a child. For so long, it had just been the two of them. Onyx regretted that she didn't visit more often, but she had wanted to find her own place in the world,

to be her own person for once. Now, she was being drawn back to a past that she had long tried to forget.

“I saw something really strange. I don’t know what it means. A few weeks ago, I went to stay at a cabin with Hayley and some friends for my birthday. I didn’t want you to worry so I haven’t told you yet. I saw a light in the woods...”

“The same light you told me about when you were a girl?” Gia asked, her eyes wide.

“The same light,” Onyx continued. “I followed it into the woods...”

“Onyx, I told you what your mother asked me all those years ago. She never wanted you to go down the same road that she did. She sacrificed so much to keep you safe. I specifically told you that if you ever saw something like that again, that you had to run away.” Gia was shifting in her seat, her voice now breaking with frustration. Onyx felt like a small child again; Gia hardly ever scolded her, but when she did, she looked so much like Allegra.

“I’ve been running away and lying low for years. That’s all I ever did when mom was alive. Why do you seem so upset about it? Do you know something about those lights, Gia?” Onyx heard her voice rising and tried to pull back, not to let her frustration take control. “I’m not a child anymore. I can look after myself. And I need to know the truth.”

Gia looked down at her hands on her cup of coffee. When she looked back at Onyx, her eyes were distant, like she was longing for something that was lost long ago. “I don’t know what the lights are,” Gia said, “I never wanted to know. Your mom and that friend of hers would take off on whatever missions they went on, leave you here. Your mother would always say that you weren’t safe. That someone was after her. I begged her just to let you stay here for good. But she wanted you close to her. Said that she was the only one who could keep you safe. But look where she ended up.” Gia’s eyes seemed to be welling with tears, but she shook her head and

looked back at Onyx with stern resolve. “Did you follow the lights? Did you see anything else?”

Onyx knew that she would sound crazy, but Gia was one of the only people she could trust. And maybe, if she were honest with Gia, she could find out more about what happened to her mother. “I saw a man. A man with wings. Bathed in light. He was fighting something, like a giant dog, but the creature looked like it wasn’t from this world. I saw it as clear as I’m seeing you in front of me right now. I know it must sound crazy...”

“I believe you, Onyx.” Gia’s eyes softened again, the creases on her face easing. She sighed deeply. “Your mother never told me anything about what was happening with her. Even after her death, I had no clues about what she was mixed up in for all those years after she got pregnant. She wouldn’t even speak about who your father was, no matter how many times I asked her. But the way she whispered with that woman, Teddy, and the way she kept you hidden, I knew that it couldn’t just be something simple like trouble with the law or anything like that. I knew that it was something I wouldn’t be able to help with or even understand.”

Onyx sat in silence for long seconds, trying to form her words. “Gia, I need to know where Teddy is. If she knows anything, I need to find her. Mom trusted her for some reason. Maybe she knows something about flying men and giant dogs with bright red eyes.”

Gia looked away again. “I haven’t heard from her in so many years. She came to visit soon after your mother passed, checking that you were okay, and then she disappeared. Onyx, you have to understand, your mother never wanted you to know about any of this. She wanted you to live a normal life. She made me promise, one of the last times she dropped you off here, that if anything happened to her, I’d make sure you stayed hidden. That if I saw or heard anything that seemed strange or out of place, I’d get you to safety as soon as

possible. Your mother would have wanted you to ignore all of this and go on with your life.”

Onyx shook her head. “I can’t ignore this anymore. My whole life, I’ve been lied to. I don’t even know who my father is. The only thing mom told me was that he would never be able to be with us, so it’s better just not to think about him. How can you say that to an eight-year-old?” Onyx felt emotion catch in her throat. She squeezed her eyes shut. As much as she loved her mother and missed her, she still felt a lot of anger towards her. In a way, Allegra had abandoned Onyx. She had promised so often that they would be safe and that she would never leave. But she *had* left. And Onyx had to figure everything out on her own.

Gia reached her hand across the table and held onto Onyx’s cold fingers. She looked at Onyx with a warm tenderness that felt like a blanket around her. “Promise me, if you pursue this, that you’ll remember two things. First, your mother loved you, and everything she did was to try to protect you. And second, you still have family. You still have a chance at a normal life. I wanted Allegra to turn away from all of the things that she couldn’t tell me about. But as much as she wanted to keep you safe, she kept going back to the danger herself. It was like something had a hold on her. Like I didn’t really know my daughter anymore. No matter how much I tried, I couldn’t get her back. I don’t want to lose you too.”

Onyx got up from her chair and moved around the table to hug her grandmother. An image of the creature she had seen in her dream sprang into her mind, and she knew that her grandmother was right. This would be dangerous, and she might be going down a path that she would never be able to come back from. But she needed to know the truth, and she needed to take the reins of her life for once. How could she see something so incredible and simply pretend it never happened? And how could she forget about that man, the one who had swooped down and saved her, who seemed just as

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surprised that she could see him as she was to encounter something she didn't think was possible?

Chapter 4

Onyx drove home from her grandmother's cottage as the sun disappeared over the horizon. The winding bends of the darkened, tree-lined road were hypnotizing, slightly calming her anxiety, but her fingers were still gripped tightly to the steering wheel even as her mind drifted. She couldn't help but feel like a child who was being shielded from reality, scolded for being too curious. But she was grown, and she didn't need anyone's protection anymore. She had to find her mother's mysterious friend Teddy, the woman who always appeared right before Onyx would be sent to stay with her grandmother, right when Allegra would be thrown into another frenzy of panic and preparation for some unknown threat. What was she missing? What would she find if she continued to pursue her quest to uncover the secrets of her past?

The last light was disappearing behind the trees; it was a long drive from the mountainside to the highway, and there weren't many street lights on the roads leading out to Gia's home. Onyx felt the exhaustion from the previous weeks finally catch up to her; the frequent nightmares, not being able to focus on her work at the *Monocle*, fearing that she really might have imagined it all and that Hayley was right. Worst of all, she had no idea what her next move would be. There was no way of tracking down Teddy, and Onyx had no idea if she was even still alive. Worst of all, there seemed to be no way of finding the winged man who had saved her that night.

As she turned a bend in the road, something a few feet ahead caught her attention. A flash in her headlights, and she suddenly gasped in fright and pushed her foot down on the brakes, her tires screeching to a halt. Someone stood in the middle of the road, a man in a long-sleeved black shirt and dark pants, his eyes trained on Onyx's car in front of him. His face was deadly serious as his dark eyes reflected in Onyx's headlamps. She saw the high, sharp cheekbones and dark brown, short messy waves of hair. He had a strong, athletic frame, with broad shoulders and arms that bulged in the black shirt. His eyes scanned the area briefly, and then he looked back at Onyx; the expression was unnerving, a blank stare that penetrated Onyx in the car. She instantly felt a rush of fear, her gut telling her that it would be best to drive around him and get away as fast as she could. Nothing good could come from being close to the mysterious man. But for some reason she was frozen. A few seconds passed in silence, only the rumbling of her engine penetrating the quiet night. Onyx's breath was shallow and quick. And then the man raised his hand in a gesture of greeting. He gave her a large, put-on smile, and in that moment Onyx realized that he was very handsome, someone she would definitely have been drawn to if not for the strange circumstances of their encounter on the dark road. The man pointed behind him, and in a muffled voice Onyx heard him speak, his voice cheerful as he said something about needing help.

Onyx knew that it would be foolish to talk to the man. Despite her apprehension, she rolled down her window and called out, "Is everything okay?"

The man walked over to her side of the car and maintained his broad smile. His heavy eyebrows and dark brown eyes were still unnerving, but the smile was disarming and Onyx returned a muted smile of her own. "Thanks for stopping. My car broke down in the road up ahead and I've

been waiting for someone to come down this way. Phone died and it's still quite a distance to the highway, so I'm stranded."

Onyx looked ahead in the road but didn't see a car or any lights. "It's really dangerous to stand in the middle of the road like that," she said. "I could have hit you."

The man put his hand on her car door, the fingers reaching over the rolled-down window, and Onyx saw the pale skin of his large hands. "I'm sorry if I frightened you. That was probably stupid of me. I was walking down the road to get to the next town and ask for help, and I must've just been a bit absent-minded and walked into the road. So dark out here..."

Onyx tried to think of a lie to get away from the man. Despite his charming smile, she couldn't shake the feeling that he was being dishonest with her. There was something threatening in the way he approached her, his broad frame almost filling her view as he stood next to her car window. She finally spoke, deepening her voice slightly, "I'm happy to call for help. I was supposed to meet my boyfriend at the bar just down the road. I'm already late, so he'll probably be worried if I'm not there soon and come looking for me. But once I get there, I'll call a cab or call someone to come and help you. How does that sound?"

The man leaned in even closer, and now Onyx could see the fullness of his lips and the dark brown eyes in even clearer focus. "That sounds great, thanks. My name's Lucian, by the way." He reached out his hand in greeting, and after a second of hesitation, Onyx feebly lifted her own hand to touch his. It was warm to the touch, soft, even inviting. She continued staring into his eyes.

"Nice to meet you, Lucian. My name's Claire," she lied. She could feel the skin on her face become flush, her eyes stinging slightly.

Lucian lifted his eyebrow, his expression now morphing into a smirk. "That's not your real name..."

Onyx was still holding Lucian's hand in greeting, and she felt his grip tighten slightly as her palm became clammy. She felt her heartbeat growing stronger and faster, almost hearing it, and she readied her foot over the gas pedal. "What do you mean? Of course it's my name."

Lucian finally softened his grip and broke free from the handshake. He took a step away from the window. "There's no need for us to lie to each other, Onyx."

In a second, he had opened her car door and was holding her arm. She tried to put her car into drive but the panic had made her movements erratic. She pulled her arm away from Lucian and jumped over to the passenger seat.

"Don't run away, Onyx. I'm trying to help you." Lucian's voice was controlled and quiet, almost hissing.

Onyx managed to open the passenger door and stumbled out of the car, getting to her feet as quickly as she could and taking off into the field next to the road. She ran as fast as she could, trying to stay quiet so that Lucian would not be able to track her. She couldn't see much in front of her as the dark descended like a blanket, but she pushed on. Despite moving quickly and hearing nothing behind her, she felt like she could feel Lucian's breath on her neck, like she would not be able to escape him. She heard him call out to her from about 50 feet away, "We aren't trying to hurt you. I just want to talk. You saw the Celestial, didn't you?"

Onyx stopped in her tracks. The word hung in the air: Celestial. She had heard her mother use that word in hushed voices, especially with her friend Teddy. She had always known the word was important, the key to the mysteries that had surrounded her young life and haunted her ever since, but she never asked her mother about it, never daring to utter the word for fear that it would drive a wedge between her and her mother. And now this stranger, someone chasing her in the dark, was speaking that word.

She felt completely exposed, but her legs wouldn't allow her to run away. She could hear Lucian walking closer to her through the field, his footsteps light in the long grass. She turned around, and looked at him again. Somehow, he looked less threatening then, his face softer. She asked: "What are you talking about? What's a Celestial?"

Lucian stood only a few feet in front of her, with the light of the moon illuminating the two of them as the shadows of trees danced around them. The cold of the evening was creeping up Onyx's legs. Lucian's expression was the same icy stare that he had given when he stood in front of her car. "There are many people looking for you now, Onyx. Something... miraculous is happening, and you're a part of it. I'm taking a big risk in even being here, but I want to explain everything to you, to let you know what your destiny is. But they'll be coming for you too. Very soon. You have to come with me."

"Who's coming for me? Are you talking about the creature I saw? The giant dog?"

Lucian let out a muffled laugh. He pointed his finger at the sky. "They'll come for you from above. Bathed in light. Trying to seduce you into thinking they're protecting you. Come with me and I'll explain everything." Lucian reached out his hand and took a step towards Onyx. She noticed again his handsome features, almost childlike despite his muscular, tall frame.

"Who are you? And why do you know my name?" Onyx demanded, trying to mask the shakiness in her voice.

"We've been trying to find you for a long time, Onyx. We knew about your mother, Allegra. I can tell you a lot more, but you'll need to come with me. We can't talk out here."

Onyx stood in place. She knew that it would be crazy to trust him, but something drew her to the mysterious figure shrouded in darkness. There was a kindness in his eyes that

seemed out of place for someone whom she should have been frightened of. And the promise of finding out about her mother, and about what had happened on that night Onyx was pushed over the edge of the cliff, was overpowering. Onyx took a step towards Lucian, but just as she did, she suddenly heard a screeching sound in the distance. The sound was so loud that it felt like it had physical force, rattling her entire body, and she lifted her hands to shield her ears. Lucian's expression changed, his eyes alert and his mouth agape as he looked around frantically. "Oh no. Not now..." he whispered.

In a flash, Onyx saw the approaching creatures, heard the thundering of their large paws against the ground. The same giant dog-like monster she had seen before, but this time, there were three of them all racing towards Onyx from the direction she had left her car. She gasped and stumbled backwards, falling onto her hands, feeling the sharp sting of a rock cutting into her skin as she fell. Lucian rushed towards her, turned to face her as he told her, "Stay down. Keep your eyes on me. You'll be safer if they don't see you."

The three creatures were baring their teeth, their monstrous, sinewy backs covered in different configurations of spikes and light markings. They were about two feet taller than Lucian as he faced the oncoming pack, and probably weighing at least two tons each. Onyx shielded her eyes, knowing that in a few seconds the beasts would descend on them and that she would be completely defenseless. The rumble of their steps on the ground grew louder with each passing second as they rushed closer. And then the sound stopped completely. Onyx kept her eyes shielded for a few seconds still, wondering what could have stopped the monsters from attacking, and she heard Lucian's voice speak gently, "It's okay, easy there..."

She finally turned to look at where Lucian stood in between her and the giant creatures. Their red eyes glowed in

the darkness, but they were transfixed on Lucian as he stood with his arms raised, staring directly at them. “They’re not used to being in your world,” he said to Onyx while still staring at the creatures.

“You can control those things?” Onyx whispered. The creatures suddenly looked at her, and Lucian raised his hand higher to get their attention again.

“Not control... we just have an understanding. I’m not very good at it, though.”

“That’s not very reassuring,” Onyx said. Only a few feet from the creatures, she could see the giant claws, the long, glistening teeth, and she felt warm fear spreading through her body. “They were attacking the person who saved me, the... Celestial.” She had pieced together that the word must apply to the winged man who had saved her.

Lucian spoke in a hushed yet urgent tone: “Onyx, I won’t be able to keep them calm for long. You’ll have to get back to your car. I’ll find you again. I want to help you, but you have to promise me that you won’t listen to the Celestials. Go! now!”

Onyx saw the creatures moving their heads slightly, not seeming to focus on anything with their eyes but acting like they were coming out of a trance, and one of them turned to look directly at her. She lifted herself from the ground immediately, feeling the sting of the cut on her hand, but ignoring it. She had bigger problems to worry about. She began sprinting as fast as she could back to where her car was parked. She could see her car in the distance, the headlights still shining on the road, and her mind was racing as she strategized how she would jump in and drive away before the creatures could catch up to her. But in a few moments, she heard the sound of the creatures behind her, the pounding of their paws on the ground and the screeching and hissing calls they made. They were gaining on her. Adrenaline pumped through her veins. She pushed her legs as hard as they would

go, feeling a dull pain shoot through them as she continued to run, but she knew it was useless. The creatures would get her. Her legs were giving in, and she fell to the ground.

But just as she braced herself for the oncoming attack, she felt strong arms reach around her waist, and she felt her hands and knees lift off the ground. For a brief moment she was winded by the force of being lifted so quickly. She was ascending rapidly, like being shot up into the sky on an amusement park ride, and it took her mind a while to catch up to what her body was experiencing. In only a few seconds, she was high above the ground, flying through the air, covered in a blue-white light.

Chapter 5

Onyx struggled, waving her arms and feet, scared that she would fall. A hundred feet below her, she saw her car and the road that she had driven down from her grandmother's house, the headlights still shining into the dark forest. A pair of arms were wrapped around her waist, holding her tightly, seemingly carrying her weight with very little effort. Her hair was flapping around her face as she sped through the air, and the sound of giant wings, the sound she had become familiar with, filled her ears. Onyx turned to look at who was holding her, feeling her stomach jump. She saw the face of the winged man who had saved her when she had fallen from the cliff weeks before, the medium-length blond hair pushed back from his face by the forceful wind. His ice-blue eyes seemed even sharper in color in the glow of the light that his body was emitting. "It's you," Onyx said, but the wind and the sound of the man's wings were so loud that she could barely even hear herself. She felt the strong wings flapping rhythmically above them, and felt an artery throbbing in her neck. She was flying, carried by the Celestial. She was soaring through the air at such a rapid pace that she felt both exhilarated and nausea.

The face next to her was looking straight ahead. His eyes were squinting in the wind and his forehead was creased. From up close, Onyx could see that he had a strong square jaw and a faint scar on his cheek. She remembered her dreams from the past weeks, the ones that had felt so real that she couldn't distinguish them from being awake. She had wondered whether these experiences with giant threatening

creatures and Celestials had just been lucid dreams. But at that moment she knew the truth. It was all real, and her entire understanding of the world had been upended.

“Are you hurt?” Onyx heard the man asking her, his voice somehow clear despite the wind. Could he hear her as clearly when she spoke? Onyx’s curly hair was still blowing in her face, obscuring her view, but she could see the city lights of Los Angeles in the distance as they sped through the air. The city looked incredible from that vantage point, tall buildings and rows of cars in every direction. Onyx avoided looking down at the city whenever she flew in a plan, and she had forgotten how beautiful it all looked from above.

“I’m okay. Nothing I can’t walk off,” Onyx said. She felt the sting where she had cut her hand on a rock. She was claspng onto the man’s arm, holding on tightly despite the fact that she somehow knew that she was safe with him; he would never let her go.

“We will land soon,” he said plainly. His voice was deep, arresting. Onyx felt herself relax as they continued to fly through the air, softening her grip. The world looked small from their height and the cars and people she could see below them seemed like toys being pushed around by giants. She thought for a second how small her own life had been up to that point, and she realized that she was at a turning point in her life; there was no going back.

“Can’t anyone see us flying up here?” Onyx asked. She wondered if someone with a telescope would be shocked to see them speeding through the air.

She felt the man let out a light chuckle. “Don’t worry. They can’t see us.”

Onyx had lost her sense of direction from that high in the air. She saw them moving away from the city lights after a while, and she finally realized that the cold night was making her fingers numb. Her jaw began to chatter as her adrenaline subsided. But she was still mesmerized by what was

happening. She thought for a second of the toy she had as a child, the plastic eagle she had lost long before. Or hidden away somewhere.

After a few more minutes of flying, they descended to the ground and approached a large house on the outskirts of the city. There were large glass panels on the front of the two-story house and manicured gardens around it. It looked like a surprisingly regular house for a supernatural being.

They landed softly, Onyx stretching out her feet to meet the ground as the Celestial man looked at her with a kind smile. “You’ll be safe here,” he said to her, releasing his grip around her waist. Onyx watched as his wings spread out wide next to his body and began to shimmer at the edges before growing increasingly faint in appearance. Eventually, the wings had completely disappeared and the glow that surrounded his body vanished. Without his wings, Onyx could finally see that his strong exterior wasn’t as imposing as she had thought, and his expression even seemed gentler than before, the furrow in his brow now resembling an expression of uncertainty rather than sternness.

Onyx rubbed her hands together, trying to restore some feeling to her cold fingers. She asked, with her jaw still chattering: “Who are you? How did you find me out there?”

“My name is Raphael. It’s good to finally meet you. I mean, to finally speak with you.” Raphael walked closer to Onyx and took her hands in his. His hands were warm and comforting. “You’re freezing. Let’s get inside. I’ll get you a blanket and something warm to drink. I should have remembered that that was your first time flying so you wouldn’t be used to how cold it gets up there. I’ve never flown with a human before.”

The words struck her. Raphael was confirming that he was *not* human. “You’re a Celestial, right?”

Raphael raised his eyebrow, pushing back his hair from his face. The blue eyes searched Onyx's features. "You know about the Celestials?"

"Not much. Just the name. Courtesy of my new friend, Lucian," Onyx responded drily. "But I have no idea what you are."

Raphael stood in silence for a few moments, clearly weighing his words, and eventually gestured with his head for Onyx to follow him inside the house. She walked closely behind him, staring at his back where just minutes before there had been magnificent wings. Now, there weren't even any holes in the blue t-shirt he wore, no sign that there had been something protruding from his shoulder blades.

Inside the house, Onyx saw stylish light-brown sofas and artwork on the walls. The decor was modern but warm. Raphael stepped into the open-plan kitchen and put a kettle on the stove. Onyx looked at the artwork as he prepared some tea, filling the room with the smell of peppermint. The artwork was mostly abstract, with some sculptures set on a display cabinet near the glass panels of the outside walls. One piece caught Onyx's eye; she ran her fingers along a sculpture of a winged woman with a sword, seemingly in mid-flight. The sculpture seemed almost alive, like it was ready to fly off its perch any second. Raphael walked back into the living room with two cups of fragrant tea and handed one to Onyx.

"Thanks," she said as she took the cup from him. She realized that her throat was dry and scratchy, and the sip of tea was soothing as it instantly warmed her. She placed the cup on the coffee table and pushed back her tangle of brown hair, tying it into a tight ponytail with a hair tie from her pocket. The windy flight had left her unkempt, and she felt her cheeks become warm at the thought of being so ungroomed in front of Raphael. "So what are you?" she asked. "Are you an angel? Is this some kind of... spiritual encounter?" Onyx had never been religious, so the question

made her feel silly, but there was no denying the resemblance of the Celestial to the image she had always had of angels. And the way his wings disappeared, along with the fact that other people seemingly couldn't see him, made her realize that there must be something mystical or otherworldly about him.

Raphael gave a small chuckle, his eyebrow raised. "You really know nothing about us? But then how are you able to see me when I take on my Celestial form? The glow, it's meant to shield us from human eyes."

Onyx felt frustration growing in her. It had been a long night, and she felt like everyone she met assumed that she had some knowledge about things that she wouldn't even have believed were true only a few weeks before. She raised her voice: "Hey, I'm just as confused as you are. I didn't ask for any of this to happen to me. Now I'm being chased by giant dogs, stalked by creepy guys standing in the middle of the road, and swept away by angels. It'll take me a while to make sense of all of this."

Raphael nodded and lowered his eyes. "I'm sorry. Of course. Your people have called us by many names. You've created myths about my kind; sirens, Anemoi, garuda, harpies, cupids... Some of your oldest human stories have depicted us as gods, as messengers from another realm, or as guardians. All of that is based on some kernel of truth, but it's not what we truly are." He looked directly at Onyx again and motioned for her to sit down. Her legs were still exhausted from running away from the dog-like creatures she had encountered. She felt the exhaustion begin to set in, her mind blurry and her emotions frayed, and she sunk down into the sofa as she continued to listen to Raphael. "The Celestials have been visiting your realm for many thousands of years, since before the first modern humans. We took it upon ourselves to protect humans because of our enhanced abilities. Those creatures you saw tonight are called direhounds. They are not meant to be able to enter this world at all. And even if

they somehow did enter your realm, there should be no way that you'd see them or that they could hurt you. A long time ago, my people sealed them, and other creatures like them, behind a barrier that separates this world from another realm, the world beyond the Veil. The Veil has been sealed for almost 10,000 years, before the rise of the oldest human civilizations. But recently, there have been cracks in the Veil. A few of the creatures my people trapped there have somehow escaped. And they are pursuing you."

"Why me? What's so special about me?" Onyx asked.

Raphael walked closer to Onyx and looked down at her hand. "You're bleeding," he said. "Give me your hand."

He knelt down and took Onyx's hand into his own. In slow, gentle movements, he lifted the fingers of his free hand until they were a few inches from the wound. Onyx felt a warm sensation on her skin and she saw the familiar blue-white glow appear above her palm. "What are you doing?" Onyx asked. She looked up at Raphael's face, his hair hanging over his forehead and his eyes focused. Onyx remembered her first encounter with Raphael, when he had caught her after the direhound had knocked her from the cliff. She remembered the strength of his arms around her. At that moment, lifting her back onto the cliff, he had seemed so confident and powerful, like she was encountering someone from a fairytale, just like all of the myths that humans had created about the Celestials. But now, he was just a man, looking kind and vulnerable in front of her, and holding her hand softly. She felt the warm sensation spreading through her hand, and when she looked down at her palm again, the cut was almost completely gone. She widened her eyes in amazement. "Incredible... How did you do that?"

Raphael gave a broad smile. "It's easy with everyday injuries. One of my Celestial abilities. Much harder with mystical wounds, unfortunately." Raphael pointed to the scar

on his cheek. “Like the ones I got fighting that direhound a few weeks ago.”

Onyx felt lightheaded; she had been through a lot over the past few hours, and her mind was struggling to process all of the new information. But Raphael’s presence was comforting. Like an anchor in rough seas.

“You need to rest,” Raphael said, noticing her heavy eyes. “You should stay here tonight. I’ve been keeping tabs on you over the past few weeks, but we don’t want to risk another attack until we figure things out. My brother, Cassiel, will be back shortly and we can plan our next steps. I’ll prepare something to eat and get a bed ready for you.”

Onyx nodded. “Thank you. This is the second time you’ve saved me. It’s becoming a habit. Maybe you *are* a guardian angel.”

Raphael stood up from where he was kneeling in front of Onyx and once again gave the bright smile that lit up his face. “It is our duty to protect humans.” Onyx was perplexed by the comment. Why would it be their duty? What were they protecting humans from if the creatures had been locked beyond the Veil? The questions swirled in her mind. She took another sip of her peppermint tea and felt the heaviness of the day hang over her.

Chapter 6

The dreams came again that night. Raphael had taken the couch and let Onyx sleep in his bed in his large, neatly decorated bedroom. She spent hours lying awake, feeling the pain from the scrapes and scratches she had sustained when running away from Lucian and the direhounds. When she finally drifted into restless sleep, she saw the creature that had become a fixture in her dreams. Its face became even clearer, every hair on its snarling snout and every bump on its reddish skin now defined, and she saw a vision of herself standing in front of the beast, looking up at it as it towered above her, hundreds of feet tall. In her hand was an unfamiliar object, something that felt powerful but also like a curse. She looked closely at her hand in the dream, where the object was, the same place where Raphael had healed her injuries earlier that night. What she held in her dream was a flat piece of metal with strange markings, but it felt almost conscious, vital, like it was moving of its own will. It began to wrap itself around her arm and she swore she could feel the creature in front of her taunting her as she felt her panic begin to rise. Soon, the vines twisting around her arms covered her entire body, making her writhe in pain. She screamed, feeling like she was suffocating as the vines ensnared her, and she was startled awake, sitting upright in Raphael's bed and breathing heavily. Her heart was racing. She lifted her hand in front of her face, examining it in the dark to see if anything about the dream had been real. She swore she could still feel the tightness of the strange vines that wrapped around her in the dream.

Raphael's room was almost fully dark, only the faint light of the moon shining through a gap in the heavy curtains. Onyx looked around at the sparse bedroom, a small writing desk in the corner and an ensuite bathroom just across from the bed. She got up and went to the bathroom to wash her face, feeling the cool water comfort her after her unnerving dream. She left the light off, worried that it would wake her from the dreamlike state that had become her life ever since her first encounter with Raphael. Every dream felt like it was more real than the prior, like she was moving closer to the giant beast in her dreams and it would soon break out of its prison and be able to get to her. Consume her. She felt like she was losing her mind. Her entire view of the world had been changed, but even though she had seen direhounds in real life, the dreams still felt like the most frightening part; it was as if the line between dream and reality were blurring, and she feared that her life would *become* that nightmare. Worst of all, she felt like she had no way to stop it or to defend herself against what was to come.

The only help she had received came from Raphael. He had saved her twice already and given her some idea of what was happening to her. She could barely believe that there were Celestials and monstrous creatures in the world that she had never been aware of, hidden from sight but very real. Now, she was part of *their* world. She wanted to know everything, to ask Raphael a million questions, but she couldn't even decide where to start. It was a problem that she rarely had as a journalist; usually she was always prepared with a dozen follow-up questions, but this was different. It felt like her life depended on figuring everything out, but if she asked the wrong question, she would learn things that frightened her. She suddenly felt confined in the room. She felt like she couldn't breathe as memories of her dream still lingered in her mind. She needed fresh air.

Onyx pulled on her jeans and jacket and opened the bedroom door. She stepped out into the hallway and walked through the dark house on her tiptoes. It was completely quiet. The door to the other bedroom, the room belonging to Raphael's brother Cassiel, was closed. He must have returned when she had fallen asleep. She stepped quietly through the house towards the kitchen, scanning the room as the moonlight flooded in through the glass panels. Raphael was not on the couch where she expected to find him. In the kitchen shelves she found a glass to pour some water, and as she drank it she looked out through the panels to the front garden. In the distance, at the far end of the garden, she saw a faint blue glow. Someone was out there.

Onyx set down her glass and walked towards the front door, trying to make out the shadowy figure in the distance. She turned the door handle, finding the door unlocked, and stepped outside into the cool evening air. She could hear a rhythmic humming coming from where the blue light was shimmering in the distance. She walked on the soft grass, her bare feet enjoying the sensation, and listened closely to the sound in the distance. The humming sounded soothing and almost familiar to her. She came closer to the far side of the garden and saw that it was Raphael standing in a clearing near a statue in the garden. He held his hands out in front of him, palms to the sky with his eyes closed. Floating in the air above his outstretched hands was a gray sphere that was emitting the humming sound. She watched Raphael intently, seeing that he was deep in concentration as the sphere hovered in front of him. His face was illuminated in the blue light. She was struck by his gentle, handsome features; if he had told her he was indeed an angel she would have believed him.

He suddenly opened his eyes and briefly lost concentration, his eyes wide when he noticed Onyx. The sphere in front of him nearly fell before Raphael was able to regain his composure and suspend it in the air again. He

slowly reached up and grabbed the sphere, holding it in his hands as the blue light disappeared and the humming sound receded.

“What are you doing up?” Raphael asked as Onyx stepped closer to him.

“Sorry for sneaking up on you. I just couldn’t sleep. I saw that blue light out here. What is that thing?” Onyx asked, looking at the gray sphere that Raphael held in his hands. It seemed to have a liquid center that was constantly moving, creating shadowy swirls that were almost hypnotizing.

Raphael set the sphere down in an ornate box next to him on the ground. “It’s called a Telos cipher. It’s what we use to communicate with Celestials in other realms. I had to let my father know about what’s been happening here. He’s currently in the Celestial realm, but he’s heard about the creatures escaping from beyond the Veil.”

Onyx took a few steps closer, marveling at the device. “How many other worlds are out there? How many have you traveled to?”

Raphael closed the box holding the Telos cipher and lifted it under his arm. “They’re not really other worlds. You can’t just travel to them by going a certain distance... it’s more like another side of the same coin. Another dimension that’s right next to this one. The Celestials have only been to two others besides this one—the Celestial realm, where we all come from, and the realm beyond the Veil. But no one has been beyond the Veil for a very long time. Not since we sealed it.”

Onyx remembered her dream: she had seen the creature trying to break through some sort of invisible barrier. Could that be what Raphael was talking about? She still couldn’t make sense of her dreams, and she wasn’t sure that she knew Raphael well enough to tell him about them. She thought about Lucian and how he had been able to control the

direhound that had attacked her. “That guy who I saw yesterday. Lucian... Is he from one of the other realms?”

Raphael’s face suddenly became serious, a crease appearing between his eyebrows. “He’s one of the Chthon. They are a race of very dangerous people. They are bent on the destruction of the Celestials and cause chaos in the realm of humans. We managed to trap most of them behind the Veil, but some returned to this realm. The Celestials living in the human realm do everything we can to stop the Chthon from harming humans in any way. Onyx, you have to promise me that if you ever see him again, or anyone else like him, you’ll get away as quickly as you can. You can’t trust the Chthon.”

“He really didn’t seem like he was trying to hurt me. He scared me a bit at first, but he kept those direhounds away from me before you showed up.”

Raphael pursed his lips. He pointed to a bench in the garden a few feet away from where they stood. “Let’s sit down for a minute,” he said. He placed the box with the Telos cipher next to the bench and sat down. Onyx followed him, sitting on the edge of the bench and wrapping her arms around her waist. The garden was large and impressive, even in the moonlight, with beds of white roses and tall poplar trees lining the path. Raphael’s voice was low when he spoke: “The first time in my life that I ever met a Chthon, I had no idea what they were. I had only ever seen humans from a distance. I spent my young life around other Celestials. I was still a child. My mother had taken me to a human fishing village in your realm, to spend time near the boats. It was a happy day. I remember having a wooden toy boat that I floated on the water, a human plaything that my mother had found in your realm and let me play with. Back then, she used to be intrigued by the humans too. These days, she’s much less interested, but I still find humans fascinating.

“My mother had turned her back for a second, and I felt someone grabbing me from behind. It was a Chthon man trying to take me away from my mother. I screamed. He ran so fast and held me so tightly; I tried struggling but I couldn’t free myself. My mother had warned me that if anything ever happened in the human realm, I should take on my Celestial form and try to fly away as quickly as possible, but the Chthon man was holding onto my wings. I had never felt so helpless before.

“He ran through alleyways, holding a hand over my mouth. It felt like we were running forever. But eventually my mother caught up to us. The Chthon man told her he would kill me if she came any closer. He held a blade to my throat. I wanted to scream, but I just felt...”

Onyx looked closely at Raphael. He seemed distressed telling the story, and Onyx could imagine the fear he felt then; a small child being abducted by a stranger. She could hardly imagine Raphael, the person who had saved her life, being so frightened. He always seemed completely sure of himself around Onyx. “What happened?” she asked. “How did you get away from him?”

“My mother acted quickly,” Raphael said. “I didn’t even see her move. Before I knew it, she had summoned her bow and arrow and had shot the Chthon man through his neck. I was horrified at the time. I had never seen death. I remember feeling the man’s grip loosen around me, seeing him fall to the ground. His blood was on my cheek. I felt like I was supposed to help him even though he had threatened to kill me. But my mother ran over to me and hugged me. She told me that the Chthon would never hesitate to kill us, so we had to act quickly. It’s them or us. She made me promise that if I were ever in the position to save someone from the Chthon, I couldn’t hesitate either. I knew from that day that the Chthon were willing to do anything, even kill a child, if it would get them closer to their goals. Over the years, I’ve come to see

just how cruel the Chthon can be. You have to trust me on this, Onyx: they might try to deceive you, but they are only out to hurt you.”

Onyx lowered her eyes. “I’m sorry you had to go through that, Raphael. It sounds terrifying.”

Raphael shrugged and made a fist in front of him. “Let them try now,” he said, smiling. There was still something childlike about him. Almost naïve. Onyx imagined that growing up as a Celestial meant that Raphael had faced very few of the worries that humans faced. Perhaps that meant that they had a different outlook on life.

Onyx returned Raphael’s smile, admiring his cheerfulness. “I’ll be careful if I ever see one of the Chthon again. But Lucian said the same thing about you. He said not to trust any of the Celestials. He knew my mother’s name. Told me he’d be able to tell me the truth about her. My mother died when I was young. I think it had something to do with the Celestials; that blue white light that appears around you every time you fly was there the night she died. So I don’t know what to think.”

Raphael hesitated. His words caught in his throat. Finally, he said: “I hope you know you can trust me.” He gave a quizzical look. “You’re sleeping in my bed tonight, so you must think I’m not *too* bad, right?”

Onyx chuckled. “You’re not so bad,” she said. “I just have a lot of questions. I think I need to try and get some sleep before any of this will make sense to me.”

“Let’s go back inside,” Raphael said. “I can finish my message to my father tomorrow. I’ll tell you everything I know. And I’ll try to help you find out what happened to your mother.”

“Thank you, Raphael,” Onyx said. She stood up from the bench and walked back to the house with Raphael. He seemed to genuinely be concerned for her safety, and with everything

that was happening to her, she was glad to have someone like him by her side.

Chapter 7

Onyx awoke the next morning with her face bathed in light that shone through the gap in the curtain, turning in the unfamiliar bed she had fallen asleep in. She stood up slowly, opened the curtain fully and looked out of the window at the poplar trees in the garden, the light blue sky seeming so out of sync with the ambivalence she was feeling. She had flown through the air only hours before, and now it felt like another life. Meeting Raphael had been a whirlwind. She felt a flutter in her belly thinking about talking to him the night before. She knew that she was attracted to him; ever since their first encounter, his blue eyes and strong shoulders, the arms that had saved her when she had fallen from the cliff, had been etched in her memory. But was she only attracted to him because he was something *other* than human? She had found it hard to trust people for most of her life; her mother had discouraged her from talking to anyone outside of their small circle of friends and acquaintances, and had shielded her from ever being too conspicuous. Her grandmother had even discouraged Onyx when she said she wanted to study journalism; her dream was to use her public voice to shine a light on the truth and hopefully make the world a better place. But all they saw was danger. Her dating life had been affected by the persistent sense of being adrift. Her longest relationship had been six months, and her last boyfriend had made her feel smothered by always wanting her to open up more than she felt ready to. She had often wondered if she was just unable to truly love someone, and if everyone who

she got too close to would end up disappearing. It often felt like the specter of her father was always at the center of her relationships; the man she had never met, who had abandoned her even before she was born.

But Onyx had to find her own voice, even though it was something she still had no idea how to do. It had been a struggle to publish her first few articles and put her own words out into the world, but slowly Onyx had gained confidence. Gia had learned to be proud of Onyx standing up for what she believed was right, and had even printed out all of her articles to keep in a file or to put up on her fridge, lamenting the fact that print journalism was a dying field.

But perhaps because she was hiding away her entire life, Onyx had learned not to trust her own feelings and to question what everyone said to her. The only people she had ever really trusted were her grandmother and Hayley. Now, Raphael was asking Onyx to trust him, to essentially put her life in his hands when otherworldly creatures were after her. And she had no idea if she was capable of trusting someone new.

Onyx wondered how she would explain all of this to Gia and Hayley, or if it was even fair to talk to them about what was happening. When Onyx had told Hayley about the encounter with Raphael and the direhound weeks before, Hayley thought Onyx was going crazy or had hit her head. Onyx wondered what Hayley would say to these new developments; the mysterious man Lucian who had chased her through the night, or being whisked away to Raphael's home. At the back of her mind, Onyx still had the lingering fear that she *was* just going crazy, drifting away from reality just like people used to accuse her mother of all those years ago. Onyx had heard the whispers, especially after her mother had died. She had heard one particularly nasty acquaintance at Allegra's funeral say that she always knew Allegra would try to take her own life, that there was something *not right* with her,

but she couldn't believe she would hurt her child in the process.

Onyx shook away the thoughts. She got up from Raphael's bed and found her clothes from the previous night and dressed herself quickly. She heard low voices talking in the next room and took a deep breath as she opened the bedroom door.

When she entered the living room, two sets of blue eyes were staring back at her. Raphael was there, dressed in jeans and a gray t-shirt, standing in the kitchen preparing bacon and eggs, and another man who looked very similar to him sat on the sofa.

"Good morning, Onyx," Raphael said, giving his signature broad, unassuming smile. "I hope you slept well. This is my brother, Cassiel."

Cassiel stood up and walked closer to Onyx. His shoulder-length hair was a lighter blond than Raphael's, hanging loose in thick curls. He had the same strong jaw as Raphael, but his features were harder, his cheekbones lower and his forehead higher. His thin lips were pursed. He had a look that was more regal—distant—and even the pale blue eyes seemed more unnerving on Cassiel. His eyebrows were raised as he looked at Onyx. "*A human. In our home. My brother is full of surprises.*"

"Be nice, Cassiel," Raphael said, the smile fading from his lips as he reproached his brother.

Cassiel reached out his hand to greet Onyx. "Enchanté," he said. "Raphael tells me you can see him in his Celestial form? That must make you very special." The tone was almost sarcastic, laced with disdain.

Onyx felt small in Cassiel's presence, but she reached out her hand to shake his despite her discomfort. His grip was firm and he held onto her hand longer than needed. His stare lingered too, and Onyx struggled to maintain eye contact. She tried to make her voice sound clear and confident as she

spoke: “Nice to meet you, Cassiel. Your brother saved me from a direhound a few weeks ago, and last night saved me from three more. I wouldn’t be standing here without him. And up until last night, I wasn’t even sure if he was real.”

Raphael interjected, “A Chthon found her last night. They are trying to get to her for some reason. It’s not just the direhounds.”

Cassiel seemed delighted by what Raphael had said. “A Chthon? Did he attack you? Or try to play with your mind? The Chthon almost never creep out of their holes to talk to humans.”

Onyx stammered: “He... Lucian was his name. He tried to keep the direhounds away from me. He was just trying to help.”

“Don’t be naive!” Cassiel said reproachfully, startling Onyx. “Chthon only care about themselves. What did he say to you, exactly?”

“Leave her alone, Cassiel,” Raphael demanded from the kitchen. “Onyx, have a seat. I’ll bring you some breakfast. Cassiel will be leaving soon so we can put together a plan to keep you safe.” Raphael cracked an egg in a hot pan, and the sizzle seemed to diffuse the situation. Onyx was amazed at how regular he seemed, how *human* the Celestials lived. She watched him move around the kitchen; he gave her a reassuring smile when he caught her eye, and mouthed something to her when Cassiel’s back was turned. She couldn’t make out his words but returned his smile and walked over to the sofa.

Cassiel looked off to the side, biting his lip. “I’m sorry if I came across as... cold. We Celestials hardly ever interact with humans, you see. It’s been years, in fact, since I’ve spoken to one of your kind.”

Onyx didn’t question out loud how Cassiel had gone years living so close to Los Angeles and not speaking to any humans. She wanted to limit her interactions with him as

much as possible. He seemed to think of her as below him, as though she wasn't worthy of his respect. She sat down on the sofa across from where Cassiel was perched upright on an armchair, and she could feel his eyes on her as she stared down at the coffee table. Raphael walked over to them and served Onyx some fried eggs, bacon and toast, with a mug of coffee. "I hope this will be okay for breakfast."

She was famished, and nodded, "This looks great." Her stomach grumbled at the sight and aroma, and she took a bite of the toast to quieten it.

Cassiel seemed to lose interest with her and said to Raphael, "We must continue to prepare. The fact that there are direhounds in the human realm means that the Veil is weakening. The Chthon living in the human realm no doubt know what's happening and they'll be planning an attack. We must gather our forces to prepare."

Raphael cleared his throat as he sat down next to Onyx on the sofa. He took a sip of his coffee. "Father will want to know about Onyx. The fact that she can see us in our true form. It's no coincidence that the direhounds were after her and that the Chthon are approaching her too. I tried communicating with father last night using the Telos cipher, but I didn't hear anything back from him. Our first business should be to alert the other Celestials here in the human realm about what's happening. This could be important and we need to protect Onyx."

Cassiel laughed drily, and Onyx sat upright to look at him, swallowing a piece of toast that was a bit too dry and almost made her cough. Cassiel's eyes were on Onyx, but he spoke only to Raphael: "You don't think *she* might be the Sibyl? She's..."

"What?" Raphael asked. Onyx saw that Raphael's cheeks were becoming red and his eye had a slight twitch.

Cassiel didn't respond. He stood up from his seat and looked directly at Raphael again. "I hope you enjoy your chat

with your new human friend. When you're ready to prepare for our duties, you can hail me. I'll speak to the other Celestial clans and let them know that there are more of the Infernal creatures appearing in this realm. Be ready to depart for when I return."

Cassiel walked out of the front door without acknowledging Onyx again, leaving an awkward silence in the room. Onyx continued to chew her toast but face was warm with a mixture of frustration and indignation. She had not asked to be part of whatever was happening. She had not wanted her life to be in danger. The fact that Cassiel was treating her like an imposter made her blood boil. But she was determined to stick around until she knew what was going on, regardless of how Cassiel seemed to feel about her. She had to get answers about her mother, about the mystery that had followed her since her childhood. She knew that the Celestials had something to do with it. If more creatures like the direhounds or people like Lucian were after her, she also had to learn how to defend herself. She refused to go back into hiding like Gia had suggested. She refused to turn away from the truth when it felt so close.

Raphael turned to Onyx on the sofa and took a large sip of his coffee. He had a slight crease between his eyes. "I'm sorry about my brother. The thought of the Veil being breached is upsetting to us. It's been sealed for so long. There's no telling what will happen if more of the Infernal creatures escape. Humans shouldn't be able to see them while the Veil is intact, but they can still do real damage. If something happens to a human..." Raphael's voice trailed off. He took another sip of his coffee. Onyx could see the crease between his eyebrows deepen. She noticed again the scar on his cheek where the direhound had attacked him, a slash of color on his pale skin.

"Will more of those direhounds come after me? What can I do to defend myself if they find me?" Onyx's head was

spinning with all that she was learning, but she had to press on.

Raphael shook his head slowly. “The direhounds are only one type of Infernal creature that comes from beyond the Veil. There are thousands of different beasts out there, many even more formidable, and you won’t be able to defend yourself unless you have our protection. We swore an oath to keep the Veil sealed and protect all humans, and that’s what I intend to do. You just have to trust me.” He gave a weak smile, a pale shadow of the usual radiant smile that had given Onyx comfort before. Onyx could see that he was uncertain.

She sat back on the sofa. “Your brother’s a dick,” she said. She was still feeling tense from the way Cassiel had spoken to her, like she wasn’t even worthy of his time.

Raphael laughed. “There’s a lot to love about him once you get to know him. But he can be rough around the edges. Celestials aren’t very good at making new friends. There hasn’t been a human who learned about us in... I don’t think it’s ever happened as far as I can remember. Not since we sealed the Veil.”

Onyx stood up from the sofa and stretched her legs. Her stomach was comfortingly full. She walked around the room trying to process her thoughts. The room looked different during the day; it felt less homely and more like a museum. Sunlight flooded in through the large glass panels near the gardens. On the far wall near the kitchen she saw some artwork depicting Celestials, many of them in battle. “I don’t know what I’m supposed to do. There’s so much you’re telling me that I can’t make sense of. So many new dangers that I have to face. Raphael, I need to know one thing...” Onyx turned to face him, staring deep into his eyes. “The night my mother died, I saw the same lights that appear when you get your wings. They were surrounding our car. My mother seemed scared. Petrified. Did your people have

anything to do with what happened to her? Were you the ones who were after her?"

Raphael stood up and walked over to Onyx. She saw the look of compassion in his eyes. His voice was low, reassuring, when he spoke: "Onyx, I promise you, Celestials would never harm a human. I don't know what happened to your mother, but we have only ever interfered in the matters of humans when there was a threat from the Chthon. If there were Celestials there that night, they would have been there to try and protect your mother. I don't know why you're able to see us in our Celestial form, but we'll get answers to everything. I promise you."

Onyx felt her heart grow heavy. Her eyes stung as tears formed. "So the Chthon killed my mother? Why would they do that? Who are they?" She felt a hot tear fall down her cheek and Raphael moved closer to embrace her. She felt small in his arms, just like the night he had lifted her up onto the cliff.

"I'm so sorry that you lost your mother, Onyx. If the Celestials were there that night, there would be some record of it at the Council of Elders. We keep records every time we battle a Chthon, and the Celestials must have been there to try to protect your mother. I'll do everything I can to help you find out what happened." He held her tightly as her body shook through sobs. She was surprised by her own emotion. She was finally closer to finding out what had happened to her mother. She should have been happy in that moment to be standing at the doorway to answers. But instead, the grief of her loss came back to her with full force. When Onyx was a child, she had always thought that her mother was holding her back in life, that she was running away from monsters that didn't exist. But if the Chthon had really been after her for all those years, her erratic behavior and her paranoia all made sense. Onyx felt a sense of acceptance for her mother that she had never experienced before, followed by guilt that she had

blamed her mother for trying to keep her sheltered. It had all been to protect her.

Raphael finally broke the hug and he wiped away a tear from her cheek. “The Chthon are a group who sought to bring about destruction, who threatened humans long before your first civilizations formed. Their very nature was corrupt, vicious and savage. We managed to trap most of them behind the Veil along with all of those Infernal creatures that threatened humanity, creatures forged in mystical power. But over the years, some of the Chthon managed to find a way back into this realm, and those Chthon who made their way here worked desperately to destroy the Veil. If they were after your mother, she must have been trying to stop them somehow. Maybe *she* was the Sibyl.”

But before Onyx could open her mouth to speak again, to ask the hundreds of questions that still filled her mind, she felt her blood run cold as a horrifying sound filled her ears. From outside the house, beyond the gardens, she heard a loud, piercing screech. Raphael and Onyx both looked through the large glass panels to the front garden and saw Cassiel standing there. In front of him, near the edge of the garden, there was a giant direhound, and mounted on its back, a woman with long, dark hair stared down at Cassiel.

“They’re here,” Raphael said. Onyx felt her heart catch in her throat.

MEREDITH TAYLOR

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